

Mata o Muna 11 / Chapter 11

Te Vaka Faka Nanumea / The Nanumean Canoe

Note: Much of the technical description in this chapter has not yet been translated into English.

Kupu Tāua (Uvea)	Introduction
I fenua o te Pasifika, talaiga mo fakaaogāga o vaka, fo'lau mo faiga o malaga, mo faiga o faiva he mea hili i te aogā kae fakahapole. Te tāua e hoko ailoa ki faiga fakatino ni hepaki mo 'tou tupuga, te manakoga ke hahao me ke ola, e pēlā hoki mai ika lalahi o te moana, te manakoga o malalaga mai fenua ki fenua iluga o te vaka ia me ko te moana lauefa e hē māfua mai o te fai tauhoa mo tino kolā koa nohoakina e lātou a mōmea.	Throughout the Pacific islands, canoe making and use, voyaging and navigation, and fishing have always been critically important. This importance is rooted in the practical realities our ancestors faced: the need for survival, including access to large ocean fish, and the need to get from place to place in an immense ocean that has never been particularly friendly toward its human settlers.
Mai i mea 'tonu konei a vaka me ko te vaka e 'ta ailoa ki muna mo iloga o mōmea ni aumai ai, ke heke ai mo vaka ake, mo 'lou faka aogāga. I te uke, mō ona aga e pelā me he ā a te mea nei i te mauluga o "faiga" ke fakalauefa kae fakamauloto i Nanumea, e pelā hoki mō fenua ake o te Pasefika. A tala 'kai mō tala fakaholo o Nanumea e fakatino, kae fakaolaola mai ai a tala e uke ki vaka mō fakanau mo mako fakaseasea ki ana malaga.	Beyond these basics, canoes and canoe lore have cultural and social dimensions, and this realm is one of considerable elaboration in Nanumea and Tuvalu, as it is elsewhere in the Pacific. Nanumean myths and historical tales, for instance, preserve many stories about canoes and epic voyages.
A te mālosi mo te mau i mea faka Aitu, hai, fakanaunau mo lalau e galulue i faiga o vaka i Nanumea e penā hoki i vaka kaiva mo vaka ake hoki. A te talaiga o vaka he fatuā haga ailoa telā e hē pōuli tātou me e fakaoti ki ai a mafaufau mo lima apo o tufuga o 'tou fenua mai i te fia selau tauhaga e ola ai i Nanumea.	A wealth of magic, chants and spells is bound up with canoe making in Nanumea and the use of canoes in fishing. Canoe building itself is a highly skilled art that has undoubtedly engaged the best minds and most skilled hands our island could provide over the centuries that we have lived in Nanumea.
Folau mo iloa e 'tau ke matemate i te folauga ke tau atu ki he fenua e hili i te fakaaogāga e tupuga o tātou. Mōi hē ai ni 'lou mahaniga e penei e hē ni nohoakina a te fenua ko Nanumea. A 'tou kau mua ni folalau katoa i malaga penā. A tino Nanumea ni faimalaga ki motu pili mai pelā mo Nanumaga, e penā hoki mo Niutao mo Niu i vaka ke oko ailoa ki te sentenali 20.	Voyaging and the knowledge needed to navigate and successfully find land were also of great importance to our ancestors -- without their skills in these areas it is unlikely that Nanumea would ever have been settled. Our greatest historical figures all made epic voyages. Nanumeans routinely visited nearby Nanumaga and probably Niutao and Nui in canoes, even as recently as the early 20th century.

I loto i tuhituhiga o te mata o muna tenei, Nanumea mo te Tuvalu katoa koa lahi 'kī te mafuliga i ai. A vaka koa pelā he mea e hapopole ai, me koa tekateka ifo ailoa o hē ai i 'tou fenua. Ka koi fanafana ifo a te aofaki o vaka i tauhaga. Koa i ai hoki he auala ake e maua ai 'tou mo ika, ia mo olo ki matagi mo lakena. A tātou koa tiakina ailoa ke galo a tū ki faiga o vaka.

A te mafuliga o te olaga o tino o te Pasefika kāmata mai te 50-60 tauhaga i pō o te taua i te lua o te lalolagi, a faifaiga māhani ki mea tau vaka koa gatukutuku i tona fakaaogāga, tai hē taulafi e mōmea katoa. I te lahiga o mōmea koa mōmoe mai ai a vaka koa papala i matakatoa ia me ko iluga i fata a fale.

Kae ko te fakaaogāga e vaka i pō katoa he mea māhani o pō mua, he mea tauloto ke hē he vaega fakatino ki te taulahiga e ola nei, he mea takahala koa tupu ki te lahiga o mōmea e ola ai a tino. I loto i te Pasefika ikonei koa i ai he manatu mo te manakoga ke toe fakaolaola ake ia me fakafoki a te faitega mō te talaiga o vaka, e penā hoki te faiga o malaga fai tele i te kau nāteaho i motu o te Pasefika.

Te toe fakafouga o te manatu ke toe kāmata a te faiga o vaka mo malaga ni kāmata i Hawaii i te kamataga o te 1970, kae koa hoholo ki fenua ake e uke o te Pasefika, e pelā mo Niusila, Tahiti, motu o te Carolines kae fakamuli atu a motu o Māsela. A tino kae maoho mai ai kautama foinini koa motu takei ailoa te hologa o lātou ki te faiga mua, koa haga atu ki vaka pelā he kamataga ia me he faifaiga fou i olaga o lātou.

As this chapter is being written, Nanumea and all of Tuvalu are caught up in a process of rapid change. Canoes are quickly becoming an "endangered species" on our island, as the numbers of them which exist has dropped in just a few years. We have other ways to get fish and to get to Matagi and Lakena. We are letting our "canoe culture" disappear.

As the lives of Pacific peoples have changed, especially in the 50 or 60 years since the Second World War, traditional canoes have fallen into disuse almost everywhere. In many places they lie rotting on beaches or stored in attics.

But as the everyday use of canoes has become a thing of the past, something else has happened in many places. Throughout the Pacific today there is a resurgence of interest in canoes and their construction, and even in once again making the long epic voyages between island groups.

This renaissance in the canoe culture began in Hawaii in the early 1970's and has spread to many other Pacific places, including New Zealand, Tahiti, the central Caroline Islands, and recently the Marshall Islands. People, especially young people who are feeling cut off from their cultural roots, are turning to the canoe as a way to begin to re-invigorate cultural life.

Te Vaka: He Mea Tāua Fakaataata

I tafa o fale, ko te vaka faka Nanumea, ko te vaka kaiva telā he vaka lahi e fai ai faiva i moana, te vaka kaiva hoki e hili i te uke o ona faifaiga ona kopekopega mōmea ake e fai e tino ki ai. Te tāua o te vaka, heke mai i ai ko te vaka kaiva tā fā, telā e hili tona mauluga telā e hē 'tou maua o taku a tona tāua ki tupe.

The Importance of Nanumean Canoes

Aside from the house, the Nanumean canoe, particularly the large ocean-going vaka kaiva, is the most elaborate material item our community possessed. The value of a canoe, especially these four-man fishing canoes, was extremely high, though of course we do not usually conceive of this value in dollar terms.

Te talaiga o he vaka fou e hahala ki he lākau lahi pelā mo te fetau, ko te lākau e tahi telā e ola ki he fia selau tauhaga kāmata mai i te fuaga ke oko ke te taimi e tā ai. I lua pō nei a Nanumea e tai lahi ailoa a tona lauokele e ola i ai a te lākau ko te fetau, fakatau ki fenua ake o te Tuvalu, e hē loko taulahi ki te lākau tenei.

A te manakogina o vaka e hē mai te hē ai a lākau ake ailoa, kae e mai hoki i te taimi o tagata ia tufuga talai vaka e fakaaogā i te talaiga. A tufuga talai vaka e tau o i ai ni hui o lātou kae e hē motuhia e i ai nei ni tufuga e fago 'lou lima ki te haga i pō mo taimi e o'mai -- te fai mo tufuga māhani e hē he mea māmā.

A vaka i Nanumea ko mea aogā mo haga a te fenua e fai ko te gāloto mo te kamataga e lavea ai te tupumafimafi o te taulahiga o tino, he mea e lavea ai hoki a te aogā e tahi o haga fai ki vaka i te lalolagi o tino Nanumea. I pō galigali i te faifaiva i Nanumea, i te sefulu ki te lua sefulu tauhaga koa olo, e māhani o lavea i moana a vaka kaiva e pelā me he vaka toluagafulu, fāagafulu ki te fāagafulu mo te vaka lima.

I te toluagafulu vaka konā e taki toko fā te fāoa o te vaka: muamua ko te tautai, kāpeni, i te māhani ko te tino e ona te vaka, kae ko te toko tolu tagata kaumalōmalō ake ko tona fāoa. A te fakatokaga o te vaka mo faiva e fai i pō e faia e te tautai.

A vaka mo 'lou kasa e kakā i luga i tū kasa e teletele mālie ifo mai loto i te namo ki te ava, a fāoa o vaka e aloalo mālie ifo kae faitala ia me fai mea fakakatakata i te auala ki moana. Heke atu i te faitu a moana o te ava, ko te tāmaga ailoa koa fakafaite, kāmata ailoa o lalama hahave.

Fakatatau mai mana fai e lau a te tau nā o fāoa e i moana, e vaka luagafulu ma lima vaka lalahi, te faiga a mea tenei e kakau atu e hili atu i te 1/10 o te aofaki fakatahi tino mai i te aofaki katoa o tino

Creating a new canoe required that a large fetau tree be sacrificed, one that might have taken several hundred years to grow from a seedling. While Nanumea has a relatively large land area compared to some other Tuvalu islands and atolls, we have only a finite number of fetau trees. They were never abundant, and today they are in very short supply.

However, a canoe's value comes not just from the tree from which it is made but also from the many hundreds of hours of skilled labour needed to build it. The tufuga who makes a canoe must be recruited, and of course there are tufuga whose labours are booked up for some time to come – so even getting a good canoe maker can be difficult.

The canoes of Nanumea were also at the core of important activities that utilized the energies of a good percentage of our population. On a good night of fishing at Nanumea a decade or two ago, about 25 of the community's 40-45 vaka kaiva might go to sea.

Each of these canoes required a 4-man crew: first a tautai, captain, who usually was the "owner" of the canoe and who recruited three other strong young men for his crew, his faoa. Canoes would be prepared for the night's fishing by the captain, who would gather all the necessary gear and decide on the correct timing for setting out to sea.

The canoes, their pressure lamps hissing brightly, would move slowly along the lagoon shore toward the pass, the crews paddling gracefully and talking or joking as they went. Once outside the pass in the open ocean just beyond the reef, tāmaga groups would form and fishing for hahave would begin.

Consider that if there were 100 young men out fishing for hahave, using 25 large canoes, as much as a tenth of the total resident population of Nanumea would be involved in fishing on that

Nanumea, i te pō pōuli e tahi. A te faiga o faiva penei e kakau katoa i ai a te taulahiga o te tagata malolosi o Nanumea.

night. In actuality, most Nanumean young men usually participated, as had young men for generations, giving fishing an immense cultural importance.

Te Vaka Kaiva

A te vaka kaiva i Nanumea ko te vaka e hili i te uke mamafa kae lahi hoki a haga e fai ki ai i talaigina a vaka katoa ki tino o Nanumea, e pelā me he selau mo te afa tauhaga koa olo.

A te vaka kaiva ko te vaka telā e fakapatino tonu me he vaka faiki i te moana ki faiva ake konei: ko te hīhī-atu mo te lalama hahave. Kae mafai o maua a ika 'lahi manafai e fakaaogā a vaiva ake: te hele pāla, tuiaki mo te holoaki.

Vaka kaiva e noho pelā ki te gafa fā mo te aga fā ki te aga valu i te loa. E māhāni o faite ki te fetau (*Callophylum inophyllum*), kae l ai hoki ni vaka kaiva (e hē uke) e talai ki a puka (*Pisonia grandis*).

E tausi faka'lei e pelā me he tamaliki foliki. E pūlou kae fakamalō mana 'to te vaiua, kae puipui faka'lei hoki mana faite/mafā/maofa tena kogā koga.

The Vaka Kaiva

The Nanumean vaka kaiva was the pinnacle of sophisticated canoe making in Nanumea, at least in the past century and a half.

The vaka kaiva is a canoe specifically designed as an ocean fishing canoe for these fishing types: hīhī-atu and lalama hahave. Large fish may also be obtained using other fishing methods: hele pāla, tuiaki and holoaki.

The vaka kaiva is about 4 gafa (fathoms) to 4 gafa and 4-8 aga in length. It is usually made from fetau wood (*Callophylum inophyllum*), though there are also vaka kaiva (rare) carved from puka (*Pisonia grandis*).

It is cared for like a small child. It is covered and dried when it gets wet from rain, and each part is carefully maintained when it is cracked/split/broken.

Kiato o te Vaka Kaiva

Vaika kaiva e tofo te fāoa e toko fā mo nohoaga i luga o te vaka. A nohoaga takitahi he vaega i te talaiga o te vaka, i vaka katoa e i ai ailoa ni kiato mo puke mai a te ama.

Kiato matakatea:

Ko te kiato telā ki mua.

Kiato hupa (me kiato loto):

Tona uiga, ko tino fou e hopo ki luga i te vaka kaiva e fakanoho i te kiato hupa me e hēai he nā iloa i faifaiga i luga i te vaka.

Seats (Kiato) of the Vaka Kaiva

A Vaka kaiva canoe seats four men. Each seat (kiato) is also a part of the canoe's structure and, in most cases, consists of the strut that connects the body of the canoe to the outrigger.

Kiato matakatea:

This is the first strut at the front of the canoe.

Kiato hupa (me kiato loto):

The middle strut. Humorously called 'the silly seat' because this is where someone new to

fishing or not very knowledgeable about canoes is seated.

Kiato muli:

Ko te hikitaga o te vaka.

Kiato muli:

The rear strut, also used to pick up the canoe when it is carried.

Tautai:

Te tino telā e ona te vaka. E māhani hoki o kaivagina e te tautai ake he vaka kaiva mana mahaki te tino e ona te vaka ia me 'galo ki he fenua ake, te tautai lā tenei koa kaiva e ia he vaka, te tautai telā koa oti ni lau.

Tautai:

The seat of the captain of the canoe. This is usually the owner of the canoe. The tautai should be a fisherman who has achieved lau: caught 100 or more atu or tavatava in a single fishing expedition, or noosed 10 or more pāla in a single expedition, and presented them to the community as a gift in the āhiga.

Talaiaga o he Vaka Kaiva

Mataupu konei e aogā hoki me koa faka ali atu i te mafaga o galuega i te talaiga o he vaka fou.

Making (Talaiaga) a Vaka Kaiva

This list of topics provides a helpful summary of the complex process of canoe construction and the many issues involved.

1. Te Lākau – maua i fea? E 'togi?

E mafai o 'togi hau fetau mai he tino ake kafai hēai hau fetau. I te 1980s, koa \$500 tana 'togi. E mafai o maua hau fetau mana faka mealofagina e he tino ki a koe. E mafai hoki o huiaki tau fetau tai foliki mo he tino koa kau i te vaka tana fetau.

1. The tree – where to get it? What is the cost?

You can purchase a fetau tree from someone if you have none. In the 1980s, the price was \$500. You may obtain a fetau tree as a gift from someone. You may also exchange a small fetau for a share in the canoe made from their tree.

2. Koa lava lākau e 'toe i Nanumea?

Koi uke ailoa lākau, fetau koi 'toe.

2. Sufficiency of trees remaining in Nanumea?

As long as there are enough trees, fetau remain.

3. Halaga o he tufuga.

E pelā mo te tū, e 'tau o fano he tino ia me he toko lua tino mātua o 'tou kāiga ki te fale o te tufuga o fakamolemole ki ai e uiga mo te talaiga o 'tou vaka.

3. Finding the tufuga (canoe builder).

As is customary, one must go with two elders of your family to the tufuga's house to politely request that he build your canoe.

4. Fāgaiga o te tufuga mo ona putukau luani.

4. Feeding the tufuga and those helping him.

I pō mua, e fāgai te tufuga mo ana tino fesoasoani, e 'kave hoki ni meakai ke lava te tausiga o te kāiga o te tufuga. E 'pau ailoa te vaka lahi mo te vaka foliki, e fāgai katoa.

5. Mea Fai Galuenga a te Tufuga.

A mea fai gāluega e a te tufuga. E lua hele 'lahi, lua hele foliki, lua me tolu toki talai 'lahi, lua me tolu toki talai foliki, lua toki fota, lua tipatipa 'lahi, lua tipatipa foliki, te 'mili mo matā 'mili mo tele 3 in, 6 in, mo te 9 inisi. Ka ko mea katoa e fakatokagina e te tino e ona te vaka.

6. Fakaotiga o te Vaka: Kāiga fakamanuia.

Fakaotiga o te vaka, e māhani o fakalaga i tai, e hopo a tino toko fā iluga, koa pula ai te tufuga me tō ki katea ia me tō ama te vaka kae kafai e laga tonu koa 'lei. E i ai he kaiga fakamanuia o te vaka mana koa oti ni talai faka'lei.

7. "Toki" o te Tufuga – me ko style o te tufuga?

E 'pau katoa tufuga mo olotou toki, kae tonu me kehekehe katoa tufuga mo olotou talaiga e pelā hoki mo olotou fakamunaga. E pelā mo te tū mo te māhani o Nanumea, ka fai e i ai he poto o he kāiga, e faigatā o fakailoa ki tino ake, e akoako ailoa ki kautama o te lotou kāiga tonu.

In the past, the tufuga and his helpers were fed, and food was also brought to sustain the tufuga's family. This applied to both large and small canoes, all were fed.

5. Tools of the tufuga.

The tufuga's tools include: two large adzes, two small adzes, two to three large carving adzes, two to three small carving adzes, two finishing adzes, two large chisels, two small chisels, the plane and plane blades of sizes 3 in, 6 in, and 9 inches. All of these are provided by the canoe owner.

6. Completion of the canoe: Blessing ceremony.

When the canoe is completed, it is usually launched at sea, four men climb aboard, and the tufuga checks whether it lists to the outrigger side or the opposite side – if it floats level, it is good. There is a blessing ceremony for the canoe once it is fully carved.

7. Differences between tufuga – style of the craftsman?

Every tufuga has their own tools, but each tufuga differs in their carving style and finishing. As is the custom of Nanumea, if a family has specialized knowledge, it is difficult to share with outsiders, it is taught only to the youths of that family itself.

Vaega a Vaka Ake

Me hē ko vaka kaiva ailoa e fakaaogina i Nanumea. E i ai vaega a vaka ake.

Vaka Malaga:

E fakaaogā mo fai gāluega, mo olo ki te talo i Lakena, ia me ko Matagi o fai niu, fai lau mo fai a fale, mo fekau ake i mea tau gāluega. A vaka renei mafai o lahi pelā mo he vaka kaiva ma lātou hēai a kope a te faiva kae hē fakaaogina lātou o fai ika i moana.

Other Types of Canoes

In addition to vaka kaiva canoes, Nanumeans also use several other types of canoe.

Vaka Malaga:

Used for a wide variety of tasks, such as going to Lakena to work in the taro pits or to Matagi to get coconuts, pandanus leaves for thatching a house, and various other errands and work. Often as large as a vaka kaiva, but not outfitted or maintained for open ocean work.

Vaka Foliki/Tā Tahi:

E fakaaogā mo faifaiva i moana/namo. E mafai hoki o fano mō koe ki Lakena me ko Matagi mana fano koe tokotahi.

Vaka Kilipati:

A type of small canoe adopted from Kiribati. Usually, tā tahi or tā lua. Very light weight since the hull is built with very thin overlapping planks of wood. Used for lagoon fishing or ocean fishing if it is very calm, and for trips within the lagoon to Lakena or Matagi.

Te tausiga/atafaiga o vaka konei mai luga: E 'pau katoa te atafaiga o vaka konei mo te vaka kaiva. Nā e kehekehe ailoa fakaaogāga o lātou. E 'pau katoa tino Nanumea i tausiga/atafaiga olotou vaka, te taulahiga o lātou e tausī faka'lei me ko te ola e tahi o te kāiga.

Vaka Foliki/Tā Tahi:

Used for fishing in the ocean and lagoon. Also used to travel to other parts of the atoll such as Lakena and Matagi by just a single person.

Vaka Kilipati:

A type of small canoe adopted from Kiribati. Usually, tā tahi or tā lua. Very light weight since the hull is built with very thin overlapping planks of wood. Used for lagoon fishing or ocean fishing if it is very calm, and for trips within the lagoon to Lakena or Matagi.

The care given to these other types of canoe is equivalent to the care given a vaka kaiva, even though the uses to which they are put differ. Most Nanumeans put great effort into looking after all their canoes because they provide the fundamental living of the family.

Iloga Ake mai a Tie Maheu

Tie offered this information when he talked with Keith and Anne in Nanumea in January 2004. We interviewed him, writing rough notes as he talked, in a mixture of English and Nanumean.

- It wasn't until the 1980s and 1990s that people started asking tufuga to make them a canoe. Before this, the island's tufuga just made the canoes of the fenua, such as a vaka aloalo for the holiday races.

- In the past there were plenty of trees to make canoes from because hē talai vaka e uke. Tautai hē fai valevale. Kafai hē ai hau mulivaka, you have to just be a crew member.

- In the past, people weren't free just to take on the tautai role. But by my time, anyone could be a tautai. As restrictions decreased, the number of

Information from Tie Maheu

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- In the past there were plenty of trees to make canoes from. Canoes were not made carelessly. If you had no canoe stern, you had to just be a crew member.

- In the past, people weren't free just to take on the tautai role. But by my time, anyone could be a tautai. As restrictions decreased, the number of

tautai increased and there weren't enough trees any more.

- The lifespan of a vaka kaiva is ten to twenty years.

- When a suitable tree has been found, the tufuga goes to see it. He decides how it will be felled and which part to use. The trunk is stripped of bark (fole) and cut off. He mainly instructs others in this work. Then futi ki tai (pull to the sea).

- Every morning and evening, the owner of a canoe should huki kapau covering the canoe, ahu any rain in it. Dry it inside with special cloth. Even in good weather, check to see that the kapau are laying correctly.

- If the fetau tree for a canoe comes from another family, te pakupaku (share of the catch) is given to one of their elders. For large fish like pāla, atu, the head is given. The rest is for the crew and tautai. Shark: the fatualo (belly) is given. Hahave: 1 out of 10 caught.

- "Tautai koa oti ni lau, or katoa in other fish." Cannot tautai in someone else's canoe unless he has made this kind of gift to the island. Fish caught with bait on a hook (matau) or caught with a motorboat do not count towards lau or katoa for a tautai.

- An old foivaka (canoe hull) is usually used as a coffin, te papa o tino mate.

- Two large, dangerous fish: lokea and tapapa. Both come close to edge of reef and thus are a danger to fishermen. Tapapa is a very large type of shark, 4-5 meters! A tautai would sacrifice himself to save his crew if a lokea were attacking.

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- When a suitable tree has been found, the tufuga goes to see it. He decides how it will be felled and which part to use. The trunk is stripped of bark and cut off. He mainly instructs others in this work, then the log is pulled to the sea.

- Every morning and evening, the owner of a canoe should lift the cover, bail out any rainwater, and dry it inside with special cloth. Even in good weather, check that the covers are laying correctly.

- If the fetau tree comes from another family, a share of the catch (pakupaku) is given to one of their elders. For large fish like pāla or atu, the head is given. The rest is for the crew and tautai. For shark, the belly is given. For hahave, 1 out of every 10 caught.

- A tautai must have achieved lau (caught 100+ atu) or katoa (10+ pāla). One cannot captain someone else's canoe unless they have made a gift to the island. Fish caught by hook-and-bait or motorboat do not count toward these achievements.

- An old foivaka (canoe hull) is usually used as a coffin.

- Two large, dangerous fish: lokea and tapapa. Both come close to the edge of the reef and are a danger to fishermen. The tapapa is a very large shark, 4-5 meters! A tautai would sacrifice himself to save his crew if a lokea were attacking.

- If a canoe is hurt, koa galo te motou ola. If it is destroyed, people cry, just as though someone had died, even if the crew themselves are all right.

- If a canoe is hurt, the livelihood of the family is lost. If it is destroyed, people cry, just as though someone had died, even if the crew themselves are all right.